

Iceland in December Cheat Sheet

Aurora, deep dark, and the layering system — the checklist and bag-size math on one page.

CONDITIONS

Temperature (Reykjavik / south)	28–38°F (-2 to 3°C) — wind chill makes it feel far colder
Daylight	~4–5 hours (sunrise ~11:10am, sunset ~3:30pm) — shortest near the solstice
The real hazards	wind, freeze-thaw ice, and deep darkness — not raw cold
Northern lights	peak season — long dark nights, best odds of any winter month

THE LAYERING SYSTEM (BEATS A HEAVY PARKA)

Base layers (no cotton)	2–3 tops, 1–2 bottoms — merino or synthetic
Mid layer	1 warm fleece + a packable down for aurora nights
Shell	waterproof + windproof, hooded — non-negotiable
Pants	2–3 travel pants (jeans are not a primary option)
Boots	insulated + waterproof, worn on the plane
Warm accessories	beanie, insulated gloves, buff + a few hand warmers
Microspikes	slip-on traction — December runs icier than November
Swimsuit + quick-dry towel	hot springs shine in the cold and dark
Headlamp + power bank	dark starts and ends; cold drains batteries fast

RULES THAT SAVE THE TRIP

- No cotton base layers, no jeans as primary pants, no umbrella — Icelandic wind punishes all three.
- Wear boots, base, fleece, and shell on the plane — that habit alone moves 8–10L out of the bag.
- Aurora watching is the coldest thing you'll do: down layer, balaclava, insulated gloves, hand warmers.
- Over the holidays, pack one warm-but-dressier layer for New Year's — Reykjavik's fireworks are a cold night out.

THE BAG-SIZE MATH

- Efficient setups run ~40–52L; the recommended bag is 42–46L. Carry-on is achievable with discipline.
- Icelandair cabin bag: 55 × 40 × 20 cm + a personal item; PLAY is stricter — check before you fly.
- Camera + tripod for the aurora is the most common reason to check a bag — decide before you pack.

Build your personalized item-by-item list free at packfitter.com/packing-list-generator.html

Figures are typical ranges, verified September 2026. Conditions vary — always check the forecast and road.is before you go.